PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • PAPER 2 OPTION 26/27

Superpower Relations and the Cold War

1941–1991 • Origins of the Cold War • Cold War Crises • The End of the Cold War



Archival Primary Record: Soviet T-54/55 and US M48 Patton tanks face off at point-blank range across the border at Checkpoint Charlie, Friedrichstraße, Berlin, 27–28 October 1961.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW • THE POST-WAR BALANCE OF TERROR 1941 – 1991

In the smouldering ruins of post-war Europe, two continental superpowers—the capitalist United States and the communist Soviet Union—embarked upon a titanic struggle for the ideological mastery of the globe. From the division of Germany and the heroic aerial lifeline of the Berlin Airlift to the nuclear brinkmanship of the Cuban Missile Crisis and the bloody proxy wars in Korea and Vietnam, the Cold War redefined warfare, diplomacy, and human survival. Confront how espionage, the balance of nuclear terror, the construction and dramatic collapse of the Berlin Wall, and the reformist gamble of Mikhail Gorbachev finally brought four decades of global confrontation to a peaceful conclusion without a direct third world war.

THE CANONICAL ENQUIRIES • SCHEME OF LEARNING DIRECTORY **A3 SADDLE-STITCH FORMAT**

Enquiry 01	**Ideology: Capitalism vs Communism**	*Why did irreconcilable philosophies make conflict inevitable?*	**Page 4**
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CORE CONCEPTS Ideology • Capitalism • Communism • Yalta & Potsdam • Iron Curtain • Truman Doctrine • Marshall Plan • Berlin Blockade • NATO • Cuban Missile Crisis • Proxy Wars • Fall of Berlin Wall

Chronological Turning Points & Causal Trajectory

Fourteen Pivotal Crises, Treaties & Structural Flashpoints (1945–1991)

4–11 Feb 1945

Yalta Summit & The Division of Germany

The "Big Three" agree to partition Germany and Berlin into four occupation zones and commit to free elections across liberated Eastern Europe.

16 July – 2 Aug 1945

Trinity Test & The Potsdam Conference

Truman reveals atomic capability to Stalin; deep rifts emerge over Soviet reparations, Polish borders, and the ideological control of Eastern Europe.

6 & 9 Aug 1945

Atomic Bombing of Hiroshima & Nagasaki

The United States establishes a temporary nuclear monopoly, intensifying Stalin's security paranoia and initiating four decades of nuclear arms race.

5 Mar 1946

Churchill's "Iron Curtain" Speech at Fulton

Winston Churchill warns that an iron curtain has descended from Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, dividing Europe into hostile camps.

12 Mar 1947

The Truman Doctrine & Containment Doctrine

President Truman pledges $400 million in emergency aid to Greece and Turkey, establishing the foundational US policy of global communist containment.

3 Apr 1948

The Marshall Plan Enacted (European Recovery)

The US commits $13.3 billion to rebuild war-torn European economies, immunizing democracies against communism; Stalin forbids satellites to participate.

24 June 1948

Berlin Blockade & Allied Airlift Launched

Stalin severs all land and canal transit to West Berlin; Western Allies respond with Operation Plainfare, flying in 2.3 million tons of supplies.

4 Apr 1949

Creation of NATO & The Dual German States

Twelve Western nations sign the North Atlantic Treaty for collective defence. In May, West Germany becomes the FRG; in October, East Germany becomes the GDR.

25 June 1950

Outbreak of the Korean War Across 38th Parallel

North Korea invades the South; the UN authorizes military intervention under Douglas MacArthur, triggering Chinese intervention and trench stalemate.

14 May 1955

Warsaw Pact Established by the Soviet Union

In response to a rearmed West Germany joining NATO, the USSR and seven Eastern bloc satellite nations establish a unified military alliance.

13 Aug 1961

Construction of the Berlin Wall Begins

East German soldiers erect concrete barriers and barbed wire to halt the catastrophic flight of 2.7 million skilled citizens escaping to West Berlin.

16–28 Oct 1962

Cuban Missile Crisis & The Thirteen Days

US spy planes photograph Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba. Kennedy imposes a naval quarantine; secret negotiations avert nuclear holocaust.

9 Nov 1989

Fall of the Berlin Wall & Border Opening

Jubilant crowds dismantle border fortifications following botched travel decrees, precipitating the collapse of communist regimes across Eastern Europe.

25–26 Dec 1991

Gorbachev Resigns & Dissolution of the USSR

Mikhail Gorbachev resigns as Soviet President and the Soviet flag is lowered over the Kremlin, terminating the USSR and ending the Cold War.

The Geography of Superpower Confrontation & Proxy Conflict

Divided Europe, Nuclear Thresholds & Four Geopolitical Flashpoints (1945–1991)

THEATER I: THE DIVIDED EUROPEAN CONTINENT

Iron Curtain & German Partition

Following the defeat of the Third Reich, Europe was cleaved by a 4,300-mile military divide stretching from the Baltic to the Adriatic. Germany was partitioned in 1949 into the Western capitalist **Federal Republic of Germany (FRG)** and the Eastern Soviet-satellite **German Democratic Republic (GDR)**. West Berlin remained an isolated Western island 110 miles behind Soviet lines. Across this frontier, **NATO (1949)** and the **Warsaw Pact (1955)** deployed over three million troops and tactical nuclear warheads.

THEATER II: THE GLOBAL PROXY ARC

Caribbean, East Asia & Nuclear Perimeter

Deterred from direct nuclear war in Europe, superpower confrontation metastasized across the Global South. In East Asia, the 1949 victory of Mao Zedong's Chinese Communist Party shifted the balance of power, sparking vicious proxy conflicts along the **38th Parallel in Korea (1950–53)** and the **17th Parallel in Vietnam (1954–75)**. In the Caribbean, the 1959 Cuban Revolution breached the Monroe Doctrine, bringing Soviet ballistic missiles within **90 miles of the Florida coast**.

SUPERPOWER NUCLEAR ARSENALS (1945–1991) — COMPARATIVE WARHEAD STOCKPILES

YEAR / LANDMARK	USA	USSR	STRATEGIC POSTURE
1945 (Hiroshima / Nagasaki)	2	0	**US Monopoly**
1949 (Soviet RDS-1 Test)	170	1	**Atomic Parity Quest**
1962 (Cuban Missile Crisis)	25,540	3,356	**8:1 US Superiority**
1975 (Détente / SALT I Accords)	27,500	19,000	**Parity & MAD**
1986 (Peak Global Stockpiles)	23,317	40,159	**Overkill Capacity**
1991 (START I / Soviet Dissolution)	19,008	35,000	**Treaty Drawdown**

STRATEGIC ALLIANCES & TREATIES — COLLECTIVE SECURITY SYSTEMS

PACT / TREATY	FORMED	HEADQUARTERS	CORE STRATEGIC MANDATE
NATO	1949	Brussels, Belgium	Article 5 collective defence against Soviet invasion.
Warsaw Pact	1955	Moscow, USSR	Soviet-dominated military pact across 7 satellites.
SEATO	1954	Bangkok, Thailand	Containment pact blocking Asian communist advance.
Non-Aligned (NAM)	1961	Belgrade, YUG	120 nations rejecting superpower military blocs.
SALT I Accords	1972	Geneva / Moscow	First treaty capping ICBMs and ABM missile systems.
INF Treaty	1987	Washington D.C.	Elimination of all land-based medium-range missiles.

FLASHPOINT 01 • BERLIN SECTOR BOUNDARY

Checkpoint Charlie & Friedrichstraße (1961)

On 27–28 October 1961, American and Soviet tanks engaged in a 16-hour standoff with live rounds loaded at Checkpoint Charlie. Khrushchev's construction of the concrete Berlin Wall halted the flight of 2.7 million skilled East Germans to the West, cementing the physical division of Europe.

FLASHPOINT 02 • CARIBBEAN NUCLEAR PERIMETER

The Cuban Missile Quarantine (1962)

In October 1962, US U-2 spy planes discovered Soviet nuclear missile pads under construction at San Cristóbal, Cuba. Armed with warheads capable of striking Washington in twelve minutes, their deployment triggered Kennedy's naval quarantine, bringing the world within hours of thermonuclear war.

FLASHPOINT 03 • EAST ASIAN CONTAINMENT FRONTIER

The 38th Parallel DMZ & Korea (1950–1953)

When North Korean armour invaded the South in June 1950, President Truman committed US and UN forces under General MacArthur. MacArthur's counter-offensive to the Yalu River provoked 300,000 Chinese troops to enter the war, grinding into an armed trench stalemate across the 38th Parallel.

FLASHPOINT 04 • CENTRAL EUROPEAN TANK CORRIDOR

The Fulda Gap & NATO Tank Corridor

The Fulda Gap in Hesse, West Germany, was identified by NATO commanders as the most vulnerable armoured invasion route into Western Europe. Offering Soviet Eighth Guards Army tanks flat terrain to strike toward Frankfurt and the Rhine, NATO stationed elite armoured divisions and atomic artillery here.

ENQUIRY 01

Ideological Clash: Why could Capitalism and Communism never peacefully coexist?

CORE ENQUIRY Why could Capitalism and Communism never peacefully coexist?

[1.1] INCOMPATIBLE WORLDVIEWS: FREE MARKET CAPITALISM VS COMMAND SOCIALISM

What made Capitalist democracy and Marxist Communism fundamentally incompatible?

In 1945, the catastrophic devastation of the Second World War permanently shattered the traditional European balance of power. Two continental military titans emerged supreme from the ruins: the **United States of America** and the **Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR)**. Although both nations had fought as wartime allies against Adolf Hitler, their fragile coalition immediately fractured over fundamentally incompatible post-war goals. The United States championed **free-market capitalism**, an economic model founded upon private enterprise, competitive trade, and individual accumulation of wealth. In complete contrast, the Soviet Union enforced Marxist-Leninist command socialism: private property was strictly abolished, and central planners in Moscow directed all heavy industry, banks, and collective agriculture. These irreconcilable economic doctrines made lasting peaceful coexistence virtually impossible.

[1.2] POLITICAL SYSTEMS: MULTI-PARTY DEMOCRACY VS BOLSHEVIK DICTATORSHIP

How did Allied intervention in the Russian Civil War create lasting Soviet paranoia?

This profound economic divide was intensified by totally opposing political structures and governing philosophies. The United States was a **constitutional liberal democracy** founded upon universal adult suffrage, competing multi-party elections, a free independent press, and civil liberties safeguarded by law. American political culture viewed any permanent centralization of state authority as intolerable tyranny that threatened individual human freedom. Conversely, the USSR was a **totalitarian one-party dictatorship** ruled with absolute authority by the Communist Party. Soviet leaders dismissed Western parliamentary democracy as a bourgeois sham designed to exploit workers, insisting true liberty required the dictatorship of the proletariat. Mutual ideological hostility between the **Soviet Politburo & Western Democracies** made suspicion inevitable, as Soviet authorities violently suppressed all internal dissent.

[1.3] HISTORICAL GRIEVANCES: 1917 INTERVENTION, APPEASEMENT & THE NAZI-SOVIET PACT

Why did Western appeasement drive Stalin into the cynical 1939 Nazi-Soviet Pact?

Mutual superpower hostility was deeply anchored in decades of bitter historical grievances. Following the **Bolshevik Revolution of 1917**, Western powers—including Britain, France, and America—intervened directly in the Russian Civil War, dispatching expeditionary troops to assist anti-Bolshevik White armies. Vladimir Lenin and Joseph Stalin never forgot this foreign invasion. During the 1930s, Western appeasement of Hitler deepened Stalin's conviction that the West sought Russia's destruction. Western leaders were equally outraged in August 1939 when Stalin signed the cynical **Nazi-Soviet Pact** with Hitler, dividing Poland and delivering vital supplies to the German army while London endured the Blitz. This historical enmity between **Allied Interveners & Nazi-Soviet Negotiators** left an enduring legacy of betrayal. Once Nazi Germany was defeated in 1945, these unhealed historical wounds resurfaced with destructive speed.

[1.4] THE NUCLEAR MONOPOLY & THE EMERGING BALANCE OF TERROR

Why was the wartime Grand Alliance merely a marriage of pragmatic convenience?

The development of atomic weaponry revolutionized superpower diplomacy and escalated post-war rivalry. On 16 July 1945, the United States successfully conducted the secret Trinity nuclear test in New Mexico. When President **Harry S. Truman & Manhattan Project** officials deployed atomic bombs against Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945, forcing Japan's surrender, Washington secured a terrifying, temporary **nuclear monopoly** that altered world politics. Soviet leader Joseph Stalin viewed Truman's nuclear monopoly not simply as a weapon to end the war, but as an explicit instrument of diplomatic intimidation designed to curb Soviet power in Europe. Refusing to yield to American pressure, Stalin ordered his physicists to build a Soviet bomb at breakneck speed, igniting an extraordinarily dangerous **nuclear arms race** that soon threatened human survival.

[1.5] THE HISTORICAL VERDICT: GEOPOLITICAL VACUUM IN A RUINED EUROPE

How did the atomic bombing of Hiroshima transform the global balance of power?

By late 1945, the historic European balance of power was dead, leaving a vast geopolitical vacuum across the continent. Meeting along the River Elbe in Germany, the victorious armies of the **Red Army & Western Allies** faced one another across a shattered landscape. Both superpowers sought security, but each viewed the defensive measures of the other as aggressive preparations for war. An intense era of **bipolar superpower rivalry** emerged, replacing traditional multi-state diplomacy with global ideological confrontation. With rigidly **divided spheres of influence in Europe** separating East from West, direct military conflict was restrained solely by the prospect of total nuclear destruction. As French philosopher Raymond Aron astutely observed of this new geopolitical deadlock: peace had become impossible, but total war remained improbable.

ENQUIRY 02

Yalta to Potsdam (1945): How did wartime allies become bitter rivals?

CORE ENQUIRY How did wartime allies transform into bitter geopolitical rivals?

[2.1] THE YALTA SUMMIT (FEBRUARY 1945): THE BIG THREE'S FRAGILE CONSENSUS

What crucial compromises were reached at the Yalta Summit in Crimea?

In February 1945, as Allied armies closed in on Nazi Germany from both east and west, the Allied leaders convened at the Crimean resort of Yalta. US President **Franklin D. Roosevelt**, British Prime Minister **Winston Churchill**, and Soviet Premier **Joseph Stalin** met at the Livadia Palace to negotiate the complex political and territorial architecture of post-war Europe before the war ended. At Yalta, the leaders reached vital compromises: Germany would be unconditionally surrendered, thoroughly demilitarized, and partitioned into four separate military occupation zones administered by Britain, America, France, and the USSR, with Berlin similarly divided. The Big Three also agreed to establish the United Nations organization to safeguard collective security, projecting an image of unified international cooperation to a hopeful world.

[2.2] THE POLISH QUESTION & THE DECLARATION ON LIBERATED EUROPE

Why did the political fate of Poland shatter Allied consensus after Yalta?

Beneath the public harmony at Yalta lay intractable disagreements regarding the future governance and territorial borders of Poland. Britain had entered the war in September 1939 to protect Polish independence, strongly supporting the exiled democratic government in London. However, having suffered twenty-seven million wartime casualties, Stalin insisted on establishing a secure, pro-Soviet buffer zone along Russia's western frontier to prevent future European invasions. Roosevelt successfully persuaded Stalin to sign the **Declaration on Liberated Europe**, which pledged to permit free, democratic elections across all liberated nations. Yet in the bitter struggle between **London Poles vs Lublin Poles & Stalin**, the Soviets installed the pro-Moscow **Lublin Polish Communist Government**, systematically marginalizing democratic politicians and destroying Western confidence in the Kremlin's diplomatic commitments.

[2.3] CHANGING OF THE GUARD: TRUMAN, ATTLEE, AND STALIN AT POTSDAM (JULY 1945)

How did the arrival of Harry Truman transform American policy toward Moscow?

When the Allied powers reconvened at Potsdam outside ruined Berlin in July 1945, the personal and political dynamic had altered fundamentally. President Roosevelt had died suddenly in April, elevating Vice President **Harry S. Truman** to the presidency. Truman was far more confrontational than his predecessor, viewing Soviet activities in Eastern Europe with deep moral outrage and uncompromising suspicion. Midway through the conference, Winston Churchill lost the British general election and was immediately replaced by Labour Prime Minister **Clement Attlee**. Only Joseph Stalin remained from the original wartime leadership. The tense summit between **Harry S. Truman, Clement Attlee & Joseph Stalin** collapsed into open acrimony, as the common Nazi threat that had forged the Grand Alliance no longer existed.

[2.4] THE TRINITY TEST & TRUMAN'S ATOMIC DIPLOMATIC LEVERAGE

How did the Trinity atomic test impact negotiations on the eve of Potsdam?

On the eve of the Potsdam summit, on 16 July 1945, American scientists successfully conducted the **Manhattan Project Trinity Detonation** in the New Mexico desert. Receiving confirmation of this atomic breakthrough, Truman adopted an uncompromising diplomatic posture, believing this terrifying new weapon gave him decisive diplomatic leverage to compel Soviet concessions across Eastern Europe and the Far East. During a conference recess, **President Truman & Premier Stalin** conversed privately, with Truman casually mentioning that America possessed a weapon of unusual destructive power. Stalin reacted with outward indifference, because Soviet spies had already informed Moscow of the project. Nonetheless, this heavy-handed **nuclear diplomacy at Potsdam** convinced Stalin that Washington intended to intimidate the Soviet Union into submission.

[2.5] REPARATIONS AND THE DIVISION OF GERMANY: THE GRAND ALLIANCE DIES

Why did the Potsdam Conference conclude with bitter deadlock over reparations?

The issue of German reparations provoked the fiercest confrontation at Potsdam. Having suffered catastrophic industrial and economic devastation during the war, Stalin demanded twenty billion dollars in **reparations**, insisting that half come from the Western industrial zones. Recalling how crushing reparations had wrecked the democratic Weimar Republic after 1919 and enabled Hitler's rise, Truman and Attlee adamantly rejected Moscow's demands. A fragile compromise allowed each occupying power to extract industrial reparations primarily from its own zone, supervised by the **Allied Control Council & Four Powers**. This fateful economic division permanently fractured Germany. By late 1945, the wartime **Grand Alliance** was entirely dead, replaced by deep mutual distrust and the rapid onset of an enduring Cold War.

ENQUIRY 03 THE COLD WAR • 1945–1991

The Iron Curtain & The Berlin Blockade (1948–1949): The first flashpoint.

CORE ENQUIRY How did the Berlin Blockade permanently partition the European continent?

[3.1] CHURCHILL'S FULTON SPEECH: THE DESCENT OF THE IRON CURTAIN (1946)

Why was Winston Churchill's Fulton address a defining moment of the early Cold War?

Between 1945 and 1947, the Soviet Union systematically consolidated totalitarian control across Eastern Europe. Using what Hungarian communist leader Mátyás Rákosi termed **"salami tactics"**, Soviet authorities sliced away non-communist political parties slice by slice, rigging national elections, arresting democratic opponents, and establishing subservient communist satellite regimes in Poland, Hungary, Romania, and Bulgaria through ruthless secret police terror. In March 1946, **Winston Churchill & Harry Truman** traveled together to Fulton, Missouri, where Churchill delivered his landmark diplomatic address. He warned the Western democracies that an **Iron Curtain** had descended across the European continent, severing free nations from Soviet tyranny. Stalin reacted with fury in the Soviet press, denouncing Churchill as an aggressive imperialist warmonger comparable to Adolf Hitler. This speech marked the formal recognition of an ideological partition.

[3.2] THE TRUMAN DOCTRINE & MARSHALL PLAN: THE STRATEGY OF CONTAINMENT (1947)

How did the Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan institutionalise containment?

In March 1947, a bankrupt Britain informed Washington that it could no longer provide military and financial aid to royalist forces in Greece or resist Soviet naval demands in Turkey. Fearing a communist breakthrough in the Mediterranean, President Truman addressed Congress to announce the historic **Truman Doctrine**, committing American resources to contain communist expansion wherever it threatened democratic nations. To reinforce military containment with economic power, Secretary of State George Marshall unveiled the **Marshall Plan** in June 1947. Orchestrated by **President Truman & George C. Marshall**, this program provided over thirteen billion dollars to rebuild Western Europe's shattered economies, successfully eliminating the poverty and social unrest that had previously made communism attractive to desperate European populations.

[3.3] SOVIET SALAMI TACTICS & COMINFORM: CONSOLIDATING EASTERN EUROPE

How did Soviet "Salami Tactics" and Cominform enforce communist control in the East?

Joseph Stalin viewed the American Marshall Plan as aggressive dollar imperialism, designed to build an anti-Soviet economic coalition and undermine Moscow's defensive buffer zone. Stalin strictly forbade all Eastern European satellite governments from accepting American financial aid. In September 1947, Soviet authorities established **Cominform** to coordinate communist parties across the continent and enforce rigid ideological obedience to Kremlin directives. Any remaining democratic hopes in Eastern Europe were crushed in February 1948 during the violent **Prague Coup**, which established a one-party communist regime in Czechoslovakia. Directed by **Joseph Stalin & Andrei Zhdanov**, the Soviet Union consolidated an impenetrable ideological empire, leaving Europe divided into two permanently hostile, heavily armed military and economic blocs. This consolidated Soviet control permanently across the region.

[3.4] THE BERLIN BLOCKADE & OPERATION VITTLES: THE 11-MONTH AIRLIFT (1948–49)

Why did Stalin impose the Berlin Blockade, and how did Operation Vittles defeat it?

In early 1948, the Western Allies merged their German zones to create Trizonia and introduced a stable new currency, the **Deutsche Mark**, to revitalize the German economy. Furious that this successful currency undermined communist East Germany, Stalin resolved to force the Western Allies out of their isolated military enclave deep within the Soviet occupation zone in Berlin. On 24 June 1948, Soviet forces severed all highway, canal, and railway access to West Berlin. Refusing to abandon the city, Western powers launched the **Berlin Airlift**. Under the leadership of **General Lucius Clay & Ernest Bevin**, Allied pilots flew round-the-clock missions for 324 days, delivering 2.3 million tons of food and fuel to defeat Stalin's blockade peacefully.

[3.5] THE PERMANENT DIVISION: FRG, GDR, NATO (1949) AND WARSAW PACT (1955)

How did the crisis permanently cement the military division of Europe into hostile blocs?

The resolution of the Berlin Blockade finalized the permanent political partition of Germany. In May 1949, the western zones officially united to establish the democratic **Federal Republic of Germany (FRG / West Germany)** with its capital in Bonn. In October, the Soviet Union responded by establishing the communist **German Democratic Republic (GDR / East Germany)** in its eastern zone. The crisis also triggered formal military alliances across Europe. In April 1949, twelve Western nations established **NATO**, agreeing that an attack on one member represented an attack on all. When West Germany was admitted to NATO in 1955, the Soviet Union countered by forming the rival **Warsaw Pact** with seven satellite states, institutionalizing Europe's armed division.

ENQUIRY 04

Nuclear Brinkmanship: The Cuban Missile Crisis (1962).

CORE ENQUIRY How close did the superpowers come to thermonuclear annihilation in October 1962?

[4.1] THE CUBAN REVOLUTION: CASTRO, NATIONALIZATION, AND SOVIET ALLIANCE (1959)

How did Castro's revolution and the Bay of Pigs turn Cuba into a Cold War tinderbox?

In January 1959, young revolutionary guerrilla leader **Fidel Castro** overthrew the corrupt, US-backed military dictatorship of Fulgencio Batista in Cuba. When Castro nationalized American-owned sugar plantations, oil refineries, and telephone monopolies, Washington retaliated with sweeping trade embargoes. Threatened by imminent economic ruin, Castro turned to the Soviet Union for vital commercial, economic, and military protection. This triggered immediate economic retaliation from Washington. Soviet Premier **Nikita Khrushchev** eagerly embraced this unexpected socialist ally located just ninety miles from Florida's coast. In April 1961, newly inaugurated US President **John F. Kennedy** authorized the disastrous CIA-backed Bay of Pigs invasion by anti-Castro Cuban exiles. Its rapid, humiliating defeat severely damaged Kennedy's reputation and pushed Cuba directly into Moscow's strategic military embrace.

[4.2] THE DISCOVERY: U-2 SPY PLANES & OPERATION ANADYR (OCTOBER 1962)

What did Major Heyser's U-2 spy plane discover in the jungle of San Cristóbal?

During the summer of 1962, Nikita Khrushchev initiated an extraordinarily high-stakes gamble codenamed **Operation Anadyr**: the secret deployment of 40,000 Soviet troops and medium-range ballistic nuclear missiles to Cuba. Khrushchev aimed to deter another American invasion of Cuba while simultaneously closing America's massive 17-to-1 nuclear superiority, including American Jupiter missiles positioned directly across the Black Sea in Turkey. This secret operation radically shifted the strategic nuclear balance in the Caribbean. On 14 October 1962, high-altitude photographic surveillance by an American **U-2 reconnaissance plane** pierced the elaborate Soviet deception. Intelligence photographs analyzed by **Major Richard Heyser & ExComm** specialists revealed operational nuclear missile launch sites in San Cristóbal, capable of striking Washington and major American metropolitan centers within three minutes of launch. This presented an existential security threat to the United States.

[4.3] THIRTEEN DAYS ON THE BRINK: EXCOMM, QUARANTINE & DEFCON 2

Why did Kennedy choose a naval quarantine over immediate surgical airstrikes?

Informed of the missile installations, President Kennedy immediately assembled an emergency national security council known as **ExComm** to evaluate American options. Military hardliners forcefully urged immediate surgical airstrikes against the launch sites followed by a comprehensive invasion of Cuba. Kennedy resisted, recognizing that airstrikes risked killing Soviet military personnel and triggering global thermonuclear war over West Berlin. Kennedy wisely selected a middle path, establishing a naval blockade diplomatically termed a **"quarantine"** to avoid declaring formal war. Enforced by **President Kennedy & US Navy** warships, American naval vessels surrounded Cuba on 22 October, while the US military was placed on DEFCON 2, the highest military alert level short of open global conflict. This aggressive naval cordon halted Soviet shipments without direct conflict.

[4.4] SECRET DIPLOMACY: TURKEY, QUARANTINE & KHRUSHCHEV'S TELEGRAMS

Why was "Black Saturday" the most dangerous single day in human history?

For five agonizing days, Soviet cargo vessels approached the naval blockade before halting. However, the crisis escalated dangerously on 27 October when an American U-2 plane was shot down over Cuba. Simultaneously, Soviet submarine officer **Vasili Arkhipov** heroically prevented the launch of a nuclear torpedo when depth-charged by American destroyers in the Caribbean Sea. This tense incident brought the world within seconds of destruction. With American nuclear forces placed at full **DEFCON** alert, secret backchannel diplomacy between **Robert Kennedy & Ambassador Anatoly Dobrynin** secured a vital diplomatic breakthrough. Kennedy agreed to withdraw American Jupiter missiles from Turkey privately, while Khrushchev agreed to dismantle and withdraw all Soviet missiles from Cuba, successfully averting an apocalyptic thermonuclear war. This confidential diplomacy resolved the crisis without military confrontation.

[4.5] DE-ESCALATION AND DETERRENCE: THE HOTLINE & PARTIAL TEST BAN TREATY

What secret compromises resolved the crisis, and what were the long-term results?

The peaceful resolution of the Cuban Missile Crisis prompted a period of cautious diplomatic détente between the superpowers. Having stared into the abyss of mutual nuclear destruction, both leaders recognized the imperative for improved crisis communications. In 1963, a direct **"hotline" teletype link** was installed between the White House and the Kremlin to resolve emergencies rapidly. In August 1963, the United States, Britain, and the Soviet Union signed the landmark **Partial Nuclear Test Ban Treaty**, prohibiting atmospheric, underwater, and outer space atomic detonations. Under **Superpower Leadership & UN** oversight, the crisis demonstrated that while nuclear arsenals posed catastrophic risks, they also enforced prudent caution and mutual deterrence between adversaries. This established essential diplomatic boundaries to prevent future accidental wars.

ENQUIRY 05

Proxy Wars: Why did the superpowers fight in Asia (Korea & Vietnam)?

CORE ENQUIRY Why did superpower confrontation metastasize into brutal proxy wars in Asia?

[5.1] COLD WAR GLOBALISATION: THE ASIAN DOMINO THEORY & NSC-68

How did the communist victory in China transform American Cold War strategy?

In late 1949, the Cold War expanded dramatically from Europe to Asia. In October, victorious communist leader **Mao Zedong** established the People's Republic of China after defeating Chiang Kai-shek's nationalists. Coming shortly after the first Soviet atomic bomb test, this communist victory convinced American policymakers that world communism was mounting a coordinated global offensive across Asia. This victory decisively shifted the global balance of ideological power. In response, the US National Security Council issued **NSC-68**, a top-secret document advocating a massive quadrupling of American military expenditure to contain Soviet influence worldwide. Washington's Asian strategy became dominated by the **Domino Theory**: the belief that if one Asian nation fell to communism, neighbouring countries would inevitably collapse in rapid succession like falling dominoes.

[5.2] THE KOREAN WAR (1950–53): 38TH PARALLEL, INCHON, AND CHINESE INTERVENTION

Why did the Korean War become a bloody military stalemate along the 38th Parallel?

The first armed confrontation of this globalized Cold War erupted on the Korean peninsula, divided in 1945 along the **38th Parallel**. In June 1950, North Korean communist forces commanded by **Kim Il-sung** launched a massive surprise invasion of South Korea with Soviet backing, capturing Seoul in three days and driving southern defenders into the Pusan perimeter. President Truman secured UN military authorization, appointing General **Douglas MacArthur** as commander. MacArthur's daring amphibious landing at Inchon liberated Seoul, but advancing UN troops triggered massive Chinese military intervention. By July 1953, the brutal conflict ground to an armistice stalemate along the original 38th Parallel, having claimed over three million military and civilian lives. This military stalemate cemented the permanent partition of Korea.

[5.3] THE INDOCHINA CRUCIBLE: FROM DIEN BIEN PHU TO THE GULF OF TONKIN

How did French colonial collapse lead to deep American military entanglement in Vietnam?

In French Indochina, communist nationalist leader **Ho Chi Minh** led a determined guerrilla war against French colonial rule. In May 1954, Vietnamese forces decisively defeated French armies at **Dien Bien Phu**, ending France's colonial empire. The subsequent Geneva Accords partitioned Vietnam at the seventeenth parallel, establishing a communist North and promising nationwide democratic elections in 1956. Fearing a communist electoral landslide, the United States supported South Vietnam's refusal to hold elections. Southern communist guerrillas organized the **Vietcong (National Liberation Front)** to wage an armed insurgency against the Saigon government. Following the 1964 Gulf of Tonkin incident, Washington escalated direct military involvement, deploying over half a million American ground troops by 1968. This marked the beginning of full-scale direct American military intervention.

[5.4] ASYMMETRIC WARFARE: CU CHI TUNNELS VS AIR MOBILITY & CHEMICAL WEAPONS

Why did high-tech American firepower fail to defeat the Vietcong guerrilla army?

In the dense jungles of Vietnam, conventional American military power collided with the realities of **asymmetric guerrilla warfare**. The Vietcong avoided pitched battles, deploying concealed booby traps and utilizing vast subterranean tunnel networks, such as the fortified complex at **Cu Chi**, to ambush patrols. Crucial supplies and troops moved continuously down the clandestine **Ho Chi Minh Trail**. This subterranean network provided an impenetrable sanctuary against air strikes. The United States responded with helicopter-borne search-and-destroy missions, intense aerial bombardment, and toxic chemical defoliants like Agent Orange. Despite causing widespread devastation, American technological superiority failed to break guerrilla resolve. Furthermore, mounting civilian casualties and destruction alienated the rural Vietnamese population and stimulated massive domestic and international opposition to the war. This brutal attrition warfare failed to subdue communist forces.

[5.5] THE LESSONS OF ASIA: THE LIMITS OF SUPERPOWER HEGEMONY

How did the 1968 Tet Offensive shatter American domestic support for the war?

The Vietnam conflict exposed the severe limitations of superpower military intervention against nationalist insurgencies. The psychological shock of the 1968 communist **Tet Offensive** shattered American claims of impending victory, demoralizing the public and forcing President Johnson to halt escalation. Facing immense domestic unrest, Washington initiated a phased military withdrawal under the policy of Vietnamization. This unexpected military offensive proved that victory was completely unattainable. Protracted peace negotiations involving **Richard Nixon, Henry Kissinger & North Vietnamese Army** envoys finally produced the 1973 Paris Peace Accords. In April 1975, North Vietnamese forces captured Saigon, reunifying Vietnam under communist governance. The bloody Asian **Proxy War** demonstrated that local ideological determination and nationalist fervor could defeat the world's foremost military superpower. This defeat forced Washington to accept the limits of containment.

ENQUIRY 06

Fall of the Berlin Wall (1989) and the Collapse of the Soviet Union (1991).

CORE ENQUIRY What structural forces brought down the Berlin Wall and dissolved the Soviet Union?

[6.1] THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE BERLIN WALL (AUGUST 1961) & CHECKPOINT CHARLIE

Why did the East German regime erect the Berlin Wall, and what did it symbolise?

Throughout the 1950s, divided Berlin remained an embarrassing ideological wound for the Soviet bloc. While democratic West Berlin experienced rapid economic prosperity, communist East Germany suffered severe austerity and political repression. Between 1949 and 1961, over **2.7 million East Germans**—predominantly young professionals, engineers, and physicians—escaped to the West through the open border in Berlin. To halt this devastating brain drain, East Germany constructed the fortified **Berlin Wall** in August 1961. Supported by **Walter Ulbricht, Nikita Khrushchev & Leonid Brezhnev**, the barrier severed streets with barbed wire, concrete walls, and guarded death strips. While stabilizing the East German state, the Wall stood as an indelible global symbol of communist failure and totalitarian imprisonment. This physical barrier stood as an enduring symbol of communist failure.

[6.2] SOVIET STAGNATION, AFGHAN QUAGMIRE & THE COST OF THE ARMS RACE

How did the Afghan War and Reagan's defense build-up bankrupt the Soviet economy?

By the late 1970s, the Soviet economic system was decaying under bureaucratic stagnation. Under the conservative eighteen-year leadership of **Leonid Brezhnev**, collective agriculture failed consistently, while Soviet citizens endured endless queues for basic consumer necessities. Despite severe economic distress, the Kremlin squandered over a quarter of national economic output maintaining nuclear and military parity with the United States. In December 1979, the Soviet army invaded **Afghanistan** to sustain a faltering communist regime, becoming trapped in a demoralizing ten-year guerrilla war against US-funded mujahideen. Meanwhile, US President **Ronald Reagan** drastically increased American defense spending, launching the Strategic Defense Initiative ("Star Wars"), a missile defense project that the bankrupt Soviet economy could not hope to match.

[6.3] GORBACHEV'S REVOLUTION: GLASNOST, PERESTROIKA & ABANDONING THE BREZHNEV DOCTRINE

Why did Mikhail Gorbachev introduce the revolutionary policies of Glasnost and Perestroika?

In March 1985, 54-year-old **Mikhail Gorbachev** became General Secretary of the Soviet Communist Party, recognizing that the USSR required radical modernization to avert systemic collapse. Gorbachev introduced two revolutionary reform policies: **Glasnost** (openness), which allowed unprecedented freedom of speech and public debate, and **Perestroika** (restructuring), which decentralized state planning and introduced limited private enterprise into the economy. Crucially, Gorbachev abandoned the Brezhnev Doctrine, announcing that the Red Army would no longer intervene militarily to prop up unpopular communist regimes in Eastern Europe. By repudiating military force, Gorbachev encouraged democratic reformers across the Soviet bloc, inadvertently unleashing powerful nationalist and democratic movements that the Kremlin was powerless to control. This radical policy shift dismantled the framework of Soviet control in Eastern Europe.

[6.4] 9 NOVEMBER 1989: THE BREACHING OF THE BERLIN WALL & VELVET REVOLUTIONS

How did popular protest and a bureaucratic blunder bring down the Berlin Wall?

Gorbachev's renunciation of military coercion triggered a wave of peaceful democratic revolutions across Eastern Europe throughout 1989. In Poland, the independent trade union **Solidarity** led by Lech Wałęsa swept historic free elections. Soon after, Hungary opened its border with Austria, allowing thousands of East Germans to flee to the West. The crisis culminated in Berlin on 9 November 1989. East German government spokesman **Günter Schabowski** mistakenly announced at a televised press conference that travel restrictions were lifted immediately. Thousands of **Günter Schabowski & East German Citizens** overwhelmed border checkpoints, forcing astonished guards to open the crossings. Euphoric crowds climbed onto the Berlin Wall and began demolishing it, marking the dramatic collapse of communist rule across Europe.

[6.5] THE AUGUST COUP & THE DISSOLUTION OF THE SOVIET UNION (25 DEC 1991)

Why did the collapse of the Eastern European buffer zone lead to the dissolution of the USSR?

The collapse of Eastern European communism destabilized the Soviet Union itself, as nationalist independence movements erupted across its fifteen constituent republics. In August 1991, hardline communist and military officials launched a desperate coup in Moscow, placing Gorbachev under house arrest. However, Russian President **Boris Yeltsin** mobilized mass civilian resistance on the streets, courageously defying the plotters and defeating the coup. Following the failed revolt by **Boris Yeltsin, Hardline Plotters & Mikhail Gorbachev**, the Soviet Union disintegrated with astonishing speed. The formal **Resignation of Mikhail Gorbachev (1991)** occurred on 25 December 1991. The red Soviet flag was lowered from the Kremlin for the final time, replaced by the Russian tricolor, marking the extinction of the USSR and the historic conclusion of the Cold War.

ENQUIRY 07

Assessment: Was the Cold War ever truly 'cold'?

CORE ENQUIRY Was the Cold War ever truly "cold" for the millions caught in its crossfire?

[7.1] THE EUROCENTRIC MYTH: THE "LONG PEACE" IN EUROPE VS GLOBAL SLAUGHTER

Why is describing the Cold War as a period of "peace" an inherently Eurocentric myth?

For decades, Western diplomatic historians described the post-war era as a "Long Peace", emphasizing that nuclear deterrence prevented another world war on the European continent. The stable structure of **Superpower Diplomacy & NATO/Warsaw Pact** balances avoided direct armed clash between the industrialized world powers, preserving peace and stability in European capitals throughout the second half of the twentieth century. However, modern global historians have challenged this Eurocentric interpretation. While Europe avoided open warfare, each **Superpower** exported ideological conflict into the developing world. Brutal **Third World proxy conflicts** across Asia, Africa, and Latin America were waged with devastating conventional weaponry, demonstrating that for millions of people across the Global South, the Cold War was extraordinarily violent and destructive.

[7.2] THE HUMAN COST OF PROXY WAR: 20 MILLION DEAD ACROSS FOUR CONTINENTS

What was the true human toll of superpower proxy conflicts across four continents?

When evaluated from a global perspective, the human cost of the Cold War was catastrophic. Historians estimate that over **twenty million human beings lost their lives** in Cold War-related conflicts between 1945 and 1991. In Korea, three million died in three years; in Vietnam, over two million people perished under intense aerial bombardment and toxic chemical warfare. In Africa and Latin America, superpower funding fueled protracted civil wars between **Post-Colonial Nations & Proxy Armies**, supporting military dictatorships and brutal insurgencies. Each rival **Superpower** treated foreign populations as expendable pawns in an ideological contest, leaving behind shattered economies, vast unexploded minefields, and deeply traumatized societies that took generations to recover. This terrible loss of life proved that proxy warfare was exceptionally bloody.

[7.3] THE INVISIBLE WAR: ESPIONAGE, COVERT ACTION & PSYCHOLOGICAL WARFARE

How did covert intelligence operations wage an invisible global war in the shadows?

Beyond conventional battlefields, the superpowers waged a pervasive shadow conflict through global espionage and covert intervention. In Washington, the **Central Intelligence Agency (CIA)** orchestrated secret foreign coups, overthrowing elected leaders in Iran (1953) and Guatemala (1954) to safeguard Western corporate interests and contain the spread of socialist influence across the developing world. This covert strategy allowed Washington to control foreign regimes without direct invasion. In Moscow, the **KGB** directed extensive global espionage networks, planted double agents, and funded pro-Soviet revolutionary movements. Throughout Eastern Europe, security agencies like the East German **Stasi** maintained massive surveillance dossiers on millions of citizens, recruiting widespread informants to extinguish political dissent and enforce rigid ideological conformity across communist society. This pervasive security apparatus crushed all forms of political dissent.

[7.4] TECHNOLOGICAL COMPETITION: THE SPACE RACE & THE ARMS ESCALATION

How did the Space Race and technological rivalry serve as peaceful substitutes for war?

Superpower rivalry was waged with equal intensity through scientific innovation and national prestige. In October 1957, the Soviet Union shocked the Western world by launching **Sputnik 1**, the first artificial orbital satellite. Soviet technological dominance expanded in April 1961 when cosmonaut **Yuri Gagarin** became the first human to orbit the Earth, triggering panic across the American political establishment. In response, the US government mobilized **NASA, Soviet Space Programme & Military Scientists** in a frantic Space Race, culminating in the Apollo 11 moon landing in July 1969. Simultaneously, both superpowers spent trillions of dollars building vast intercontinental missile arsenals, creating a terrifying balance of nuclear terror capable of obliterating human civilization multiple times over.

[7.5] THE SYNOPTIC VERDICT: AN ERA OF TOTAL WAR WITHOUT DIRECT ARMAGEDDON

What enduring geopolitical and military legacies did the Cold War leave behind for our world?

In assessing whether the Cold War was truly "cold", modern **Cold War Historians & Global Society** conclude that the phrase is an incomplete, misleading description of a global tragedy. Direct armed confrontation between Washington and Moscow was prevented solely because thermonuclear weapons made great power war an act of mutual suicide, forcing adversaries to avoid direct military clash. Yet avoiding nuclear armageddon carried an appalling human cost. Each **Superpower** projected its ideological struggle into vulnerable developing nations through proxy wars, covert operations, and economic warfare. While **Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD)** successfully prevented a third world war, the Cold War was a total global confrontation whose enduring geopolitical consequences continue to shape our contemporary world.

Scholarly Perspectives & The Architecture of Cold War History

How Historians Explain the Origins, Proxy Confrontations & Soviet Collapse

DEBATE 01 • THE ORTHODOX SCHOOL

Soviet Expansionism & Marxist-Leninist Dogma

Writing in the immediate post-war decades, orthodox historians such as **Arthur Schlesinger Jr.** and **Herbert Feis** argued that the Cold War was the direct consequence of Soviet aggression. Driven by Marxist-Leninist universalist ideology and Joseph Stalin's pathological paranoia, Moscow violated the Yalta Declaration on Liberated Europe, imposed brutal puppet regimes across Eastern Europe, and sought world communist domination, forcing the United States to reluctantly mobilize in defence of Western liberty.

DEBATE 02 • THE REVISIONIST SCHOOL

American Economic Imperialism & Atomic Diplomacy

Emerging during the Vietnam War era, revisionist scholars such as **William Appleman Williams** and **Gar Alperovitz** argued that American economic expansionism was the primary catalyst. Seeking global open-door markets for surplus industrial goods, Washington sought to construct a worldwide capitalist empire. Truman's deployment of atomic diplomacy against Japan and aggressive encirclement forced Moscow into legitimate, defensive countermeasures to protect its devastated borders.

DEBATE 03 • THE POST-REVISIONIST SCHOOL

Systemic Inevitability & Mutual Misperception

Synthesising rival perspectives, post-revisionist historians such as **John Lewis Gaddis** argued that neither superpower was solely responsible. The catastrophic collapse of the European balance of power created a dangerous geopolitical vacuum. Compounded by conflicting ideological worldviews, mutual misperceptions, domestic political pressures, and classic security dilemmas, the division of Europe became a tragic, structurally unavoidable confrontation.

DEBATE 04 • THE POST-SOVIET ARCHIVAL TURN

Ideological Conviction & The Tail Wags The Dog

Exploiting declassified Kremlin, Chinese, and East European archives since 1991, historians such as **Odd Arne Westad** and **Vladislav Zubok** demonstrated that Soviet leaders were genuinely motivated by ideological conviction, not cynical realpolitik. Crucially, recent scholarship shows that ambitious third-world proxy leaders (such as Fidel Castro, Kim Il-sung, and Ho Chi Minh) frequently manipulated their superpower patrons, dragging them into perilous crises.

KEY DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY & CONCEPTUAL ARCHITECTURE

THEORETICAL SCHEMA • 8 CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMS

Containment (Kennan 1946/47):
The foundational US strategic foreign policy formulated by diplomat George F. Kennan, aiming to check the geopolitical spread of Soviet communism through patient, vigilant, and long-term counter-force at key geographical points.

Truman Doctrine (1947):
The landmark foreign policy commitment announced by President Harry S. Truman pledging American financial, logistical, and military assistance to free democratic nations resisting subjugation by armed minorities or external communist pressure.

Marshall Plan (1948):
The $13.3 billion European Recovery Program engineered by Secretary of State George C. Marshall to rebuild shattered Western European capitalist economies, eliminating the widespread poverty and instability that fostered communist appeal.

Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD):
The strategic military doctrine positing that full-scale nuclear weapon use by two opposing superpowers would result in the complete annihilation of both attacker and defender, transforming nuclear weapons into absolute deterrents.

Proxy War:
Regional armed conflicts across the developing world (e.g. Korea, Vietnam, Angola) where opposing superpowers supported, financed, and armed belligerent local factions to project power and secure hegemony without direct nuclear exchange.

Brinkmanship:
The high-risk diplomatic strategy, championed by Secretary of State John Foster Dulles, of deliberately escalating international crises to the absolute precipice of nuclear confrontation to compel the adversary to capitulate or retreat.

Brezhnev Doctrine (1968):
Soviet foreign policy decree declaring that any internal or external threat to socialist rule in any Eastern bloc satellite state constituted a collective threat to all socialist nations, legitimizing armed Soviet military invasion.

Glasnost & Perestroika (1985–91):
Mikhail Gorbachev's radical reform initiatives of political "openness" (free expression, transparency) and economic "restructuring", designed to revitalize the Soviet system but which inadvertently accelerated its collapse.

BACK COVER • RETRIEVAL ENGINE • ZERO ANSWERS PRINTED

Master Knowledge Retrieval Quiz

Standard Recall Protocol: 35 core retrieval questions testing factual mastery across all seven enquiries. Use for low-stakes weekly partner testing, silent memory flash-checks, or end-of-unit revision retrieval. All facts are verified in textbook narrative sections **[1.1] to [7.5]**. (Answers verified in class; zero answers printed.)

Enquiry 1: Ideological Foundations

Page 4 • Ref [1.1]–[1.5]

1. What two opposing economic doctrines defined the Cold War superpower confrontation?
2. How did American liberal democracy contrast with the Soviet one-party dictatorship?
3. Which 1918–19 foreign military intervention created deep, lasting Bolshevik suspicion of the West?
4. In what month and year did the United States detonate atomic weapons over Hiroshima and Nagasaki?
5. Which French philosopher famously observed in 1947: "Peace is impossible; war is improbable"?

Enquiry 2: Yalta to Potsdam (1945)

Page 5 • Ref [2.1]–[2.5]

6. Which three Allied leaders constituted the original "Big Three" at the Yalta Summit in February 1945?
7. What agreement at Yalta promised democratic institutions and free elections across liberated Europe?
8. Which new American president replaced Franklin D. Roosevelt at the Potsdam Conference in July 1945?
9. What was the codename for the successful American atomic bomb detonation tested in New Mexico in July 1945?
10. Into how many separate military occupation zones were Germany and Berlin divided in 1945?

Enquiry 3: Iron Curtain & Blockade

Page 6 • Ref [3.1]–[3.5]

11. In what American town and year did Winston Churchill deliver his famous "Iron Curtain" address?
12. What landmark American foreign policy announced in March 1947 committed the US to global containment?
13. How much financial aid did the Marshall Plan transfer to Western European nations to rebuild their economies?
14. What logistical operation flew 2.3 million tons of supplies into West Berlin during the 11-month blockade?
15. What collective defence treaty organisation was established by Western powers in Washington in April 1949?

Enquiry 4: The Cuban Missile Crisis

Page 7 • Ref [4.1]–[4.5]

16. What revolutionary leader seized power in Cuba in January 1959 after overthrowing the Batista regime?
17. What type of high-altitude US reconnaissance aircraft first photographed Soviet missile sites in Cuba in October 1962?
18. What action did President Kennedy choose to take against Cuba on 22 October 1962 rather than an immediate invasion?
19. What highest peacetime military readiness alert did the US Strategic Air Command reach during the crisis?
20. What secret reciprocal concession did President Kennedy offer regarding US missiles in Turkey to secure a deal?

Enquiry 5: Proxy Wars in Asia

Page 8 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

21. Along what line of latitude was the Korean peninsula divided following the Second World War?
22. What daring amphibious landing did General Douglas MacArthur execute in September 1950?
23. Which foreign superpower launched an unexpected military counter-offensive in Korea in late 1950?
24. What 1954 military defeat ended French colonial rule in Indochina and divided Vietnam at the 17th Parallel?
25. What vast underground network did the National Liberation Front (Vietcong) use to survive American aerial bombardment?

Enquiry 6: Berlin Wall & Soviet Collapse

Page 9 • Ref [6.1]–[6.5]

26. In what month and year did the East German government begin constructing the Berlin Wall?
27. What were Mikhail Gorbachev's twin reform policies of "political openness" and "economic restructuring"?
28. What 1968 Soviet military doctrine was formally abandoned by Gorbachev, allowing satellite states self-determination?
29. On what exact date in November 1989 did East German border guards open checkpoints at the Berlin Wall?
30. On what exact date did Mikhail Gorbachev resign as president, formally dissolving the Soviet Union?

Enquiry 7: Synoptic Assessment

Page 10 • Ref [7.1]–[7.5]

31. Approximately how many people died in regional proxy conflicts across the Global South during the Cold War?
32. What 1975 international accords recognised European borders and established human rights commitments?
33. What military concept (MAD) ensured that a nuclear strike by either superpower would lead to mutual destruction?
34. What satellite launched by the USSR in October 1957 initiated the Cold War space and missile race?
35. How did historians define the paradox of European stability coexisting with catastrophic global proxy violence?